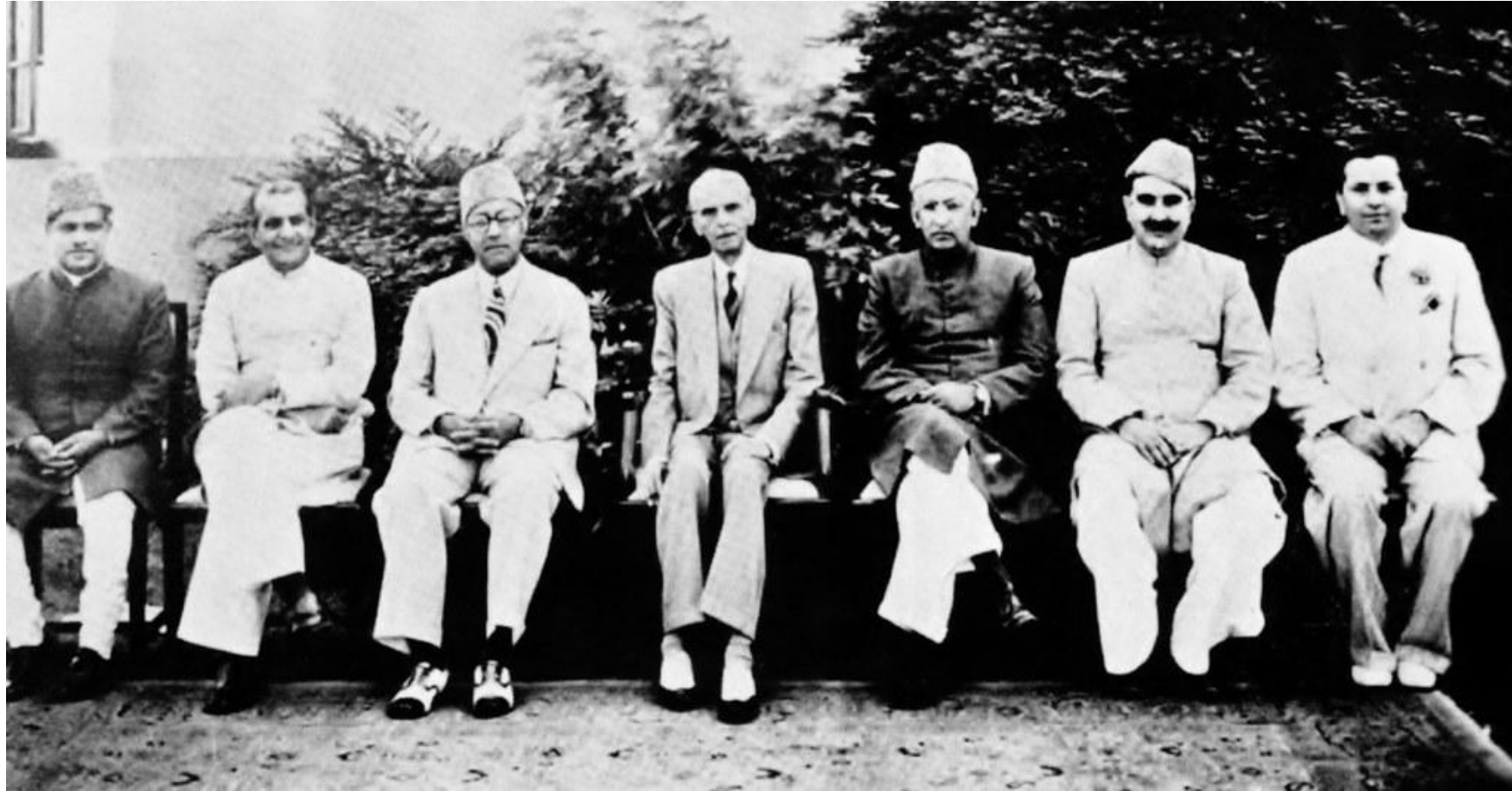


State of Pakistan and Language Movement

Pakistan

- With the partition of India in 1947 and end of British rule, an independent Pakistan state was born. East Bengal became part of Pakistan and later became known as East Pakistan. Two wings of Pakistan being separated by thousands of miles of Indian states seriously questioned its viability from the beginning.
- Mohammed Ali Jinnah, the undisputed leader of Pakistan became the Governor General of Pakistan. Liaquat Ali Khan was appointed the Prime Minister of Pakistan and a Central Cabinet was formed. Karachi was declared the capital of Pakistan, but the capital was later shifted to Islamabad.
- The first Constituent Assembly of Pakistan was made up of the members of the pre-partition constituent assembly of India who represented areas now within Pakistan. East Bengal was declared a province and Khaja Nazimuddin was made Chief Minister. The East Pakistan Provincial Assembly replaced the Bengal Legislative Assembly Members elected from the East Bengal.

First Pakistan Cabinet (1947)



Language Movement

- Though Bengalis constituted 56% of the whole population of Pakistan, the way Pakistan Govt started functioning gave a perception among the people of East Pakistan that they were being dominated by Urdu-speaking people of West Pakistan and their cohort in East Pakistan. Central leadership and Cabinet were captured by non- Bengali politicians. Suhrawardy or Fazlul Haq were left out of cabinet. Bengalis were marginalized in the central administration as well as at all tiers of East Pakistan Administration.
- Bengalis' struggle against the unjust activities of Pakistani rulers began through the Language Movement. The debate over state language began long before partition. In 1944 during British period, Jinnah and other Urdu speaking leaders of Muslim League demanded Urdu to be the official language of Pakistan. But due to opposition from Bengali leaders like Falul Haq and Abul Hashim the idea was dropped then.
- After partition and Pakistan came in to being Tamuddin Majlish, a cultural organisation formed in September 1947 by professor Abul kashem of Dhaka University Played pivotal role for establishing Bangla as state language. Tamaddun Majlish issued a booklet on 15 September 1947 titled Pakistaner Rashtra Bhasha: Bangla na Urdu (Pakistan's State Language: Bangla or Urdu) edited by Professor Abul Quasem. Tamaddin majslish also formed Rashtra Bhasha Sangram Parishad (State Language Action Committee) with Professor Nurul Hoque of Dhaka University (Oct 1947) as convenor and East Pakistan Muslim Chatra League was also formed to realise the demand of Bangla as one of the state languages alongside Urdu. Direndra Nath Datta, a member of the Constituent Assembly from Cumilla in its session on 23 February 1948 moved a motion to include Bangla as one of the language of the Constituent Assembly. But Prime Minister Liaquat Ali Khan and Chief Minister Khaja Najimuddin opposed it and ultimately the motion was rejected.

Language Movement

- On receiving the news of rejection of the motion, the people of East Pakistan got agitated and Rashtro Bhasha Sangram Parishad called a strike to observe “Bangla Bhasha Dabi Dibash” on March 11, 1948. For implementing the program students resorted to picketing around Eden Bhaban (Present Secretariat), many students were arrested. Notable among them are Shamsul Haq, Kazi Mahbubul Haq, Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, Oli Ahad, Shawkat Ali, Abdul Wahed, etc. Abdul Matin, Gaziul Haq also took part in the procession and picketing. In protest against arrest and use of force by police students gathered at Amtala of Dhaka University and a protest meeting was held there.
- Under these circumstances, Khaja Nazimuddin signed an agreement with the student leaders. He agreed to a few demands of the students but did not comply with the demand that Bangla be a state language of Pakistan.

Language Movement

- On 19 March 1948 Mohammed Ali Jinnah Came to visit East Pakistan. He addressed two meetings, one at Race Course and another at Convocation of DU at Curzon Hall. In both the meetings, he declared “Urdu shall be the only state language of Pakistan”. But the declaration was instantly protested and some students said “no” to his declaration. The students formed a Dhaka University Language Action Committee with MA Matin as convenor and thus the movement spread throughout the East Pakistan.
- By the beginning of 1952 the language movement took a serious turn. Jinnah and Liakat Ali had passed away by that time. Khaja Najimuddin was Prime Minister of Pakistan. A new party namely Awami Muslim League was formed in 1949 with Moulana Bhasani as President, Shamsul Haq as General Secretary and Sheikh Mujibur Rahman as Joint Secretary. There was growing sense of deprivation and exploitation among the people of East Pakistan.
- Under these circumstances, the movement got a new momentum. An all-party central committee was formed with Kazi Mahbub as its convenor. At this time, the government suggested that Bangla be written with Arabic letters, which was vehemently opposed by the people. In protest The All Party Language Action Committee called a hartal on 21st February 1952 throughout East Pakistan. In response, Govt imposed section 144.
- The students’ leaders like Abdul Matin and Gaziul Haq were adamant to break the Section 144 and led the procession of students towards Assembly Hall (Jagannath Hall University of Dhaka). Police opened fire upon the crowd of students, resulting in the deaths of Rafiq Uddin Ahmed, Abdul Jabbar, Abul Barkat, Abdus Salam, Ohiullah, etc.

Procession march held on 21 February 1952 in Dhaka



Language Movement

- The Assembly was about to begin the session, but on hearing about the firing incident, opposition member Moulana Abdur Rashid Tarkabagish and some others went out and joined the students. But the Chief Minister Nurul Amin still opposed the demands of the students for Bangla as state language in the session. The demonstration continued on 22 and 23 February. A temporary memorial was erected on the spot where the students were killed. It was replaced by a concrete memorial (Shahid Minar) in 1963.
- East Bengal Legislative Assembly adopted a resolution recommending the recognition of Bangla as one of the state language of Pakistan in 1956. Since 1952, 21st February every year is being observed to commemorate the Martyrs of the Language Movement. UNESCO adopted a resolution on 17 November 1999 proclaiming 21st February as International Mother Language Day. The day is now observed as International Mother Language Day throughout the world.
- **Significance:** The Language Movement is a crucial event in the history of Bangladesh. It resisted a heinous attack on our language and culture and played a vital role in rise the Bengali nationalism that led to our liberation war in 1971, resulting in the creation of Bangladesh.

Women defying the Section 144 curfew



Activists paying floral tribute at the Shaheed Minar, Dhaka, February 21, 1953.



Maulana Bhashani after the foundation stone laying program for Shaheed Minar by Abul Barkat's family members on 21 February 1956.

